

The Plague

A review by Sean O'Dea

"And indeed, as he listened to the cries of joy rising from the town, Rieux remembered that such joy is always imperilled. He knew what those jubilant crowds did not know but could have learned from books: that the plague bacillus never dies or disappears for good; that it can lie dormant for years and years in furniture and linen-chests; that it bides its time in bedrooms, cellars, trunks and book-shelves; and that perhaps the day would come when, for the bane and enlightening of men, it roused up its rats again and sent them forth to die in a happy city."

Camus is an incredibly talented writer. This novel contained some of the richest prose my eyes have had the pleasure of reading, often taking the form of long, descriptive run-on sentences with leagues of obscure vocabulary that work only to enrich the point rather than belabor it. Much credit is also due to the translator, Stuart Gilbert.

The Plague is not a terribly long nor terribly complex novel about a fictional outbreak of the Bubonic Plague in the cliff-side Algerian coastal city of Oran set during the 1940s. This story works on multiple levels, as simply a compelling account of the rise and fall of an epidemic, and as an allegory for the rationalization of tragedy. I'll begin with the former.

As with other depictions of epidemics created pre-2020 (*Contagion* (2011) comes to mind), this story has become incredibly compelling in a modern world that just lived through one of the largest pandemics in history. It's increasingly clear to me that despite how much the world changes, *plague* in its total form never really does. One can probably see themselves in most of the experiences endured by the citizens of Oran.

Camus uses the fundamental idea that epidemics breed such a consistent and distinct brand of suffering; one that inevitably pushes humanity to its limit by depriving it of all forms of love and hope. These two things, he argues, are essential to human function. He specifically describes the height of the outbreak when weariness is at its peak and the town is limping on in a neverending limbo, pointing out that when all other forms of hope are dismantled in the human spirit, what remains is a dull, grey hope, nothing more than the simple will to live.

The subtle genius of the story is its lack of glamour, spectacle, and heroes. The city does not burn as the winds of the plague violently strip whatever sanity remains, it's rather a slow, calculated plight to mixed reactions. As the narrator describes, "The truth is that

nothing is less sensational than pestilence and by reason of their very duration great misfortunes are monotonous. In the memories of those who lived through them, the grim days of plague do not stand out like lived flames, ravenous and inextinguishable, beaoning a troubled sky, but rather like the slow, deliberate progress of some monstrous thing crushing out all upon its path." Many will remember the 2 years of COVID much the same.

This story has no heroes. The closest we get is the humble narrator, Dr. Bernard Rieux, a stoic, professional man who acts with an extreme degree of sangfroid, who refuses to identify himself as the narrator so as to maintain an air of objectivity. Rieux constantly puts his personal affairs to the side to give his everything to the cause. He never asks for recognition and even refuses to bestow it upon himself, likening his work to that of a schoolteacher teaching "two plus two is four", a simple act of duty. Rieux himself states in a conversation with his friend and colleague Tarrou, "I feel more fellowship with the defeated than with saints. Heroism and sanctity don't appeal to me, I imagine. What interests me is -- being a man."

This was in response to Tarrou's own brand of rationalization. His belief is that "each of us has the plague within him," and that "we must keep endless watch on ourselves lest in a careless moment we breathe in somebody's face and fasten the infection on him... The good man, the man who infects hardly anyone, is the man who has the fewest lapses of attention. And it needs tremendous will-power, a never-ending tension of the mind, to avoid such lapses." A virtuous life is one that takes constant, careful attention to avoid the vices that we may intentionally or unintentionally spread to others, that ultimately lead to the propagation of death and suffering. This is another way of looking at the narrator's earlier statement that, "The evil that is in the world always comes of ignorance, and good intentions may do as much harm as malevolence, if they lack understanding."

The Plague is rooted in the mundane, the ordinary. Oran is characterized as an uneventful place inhabited by rather ordinary people, each with their own quirks. "He realized how absurd it was, but he simply couldn't believe that a pestilence on the great scale could befall a town where people like Grand were to be found, obscure functionaries cultivating harmless eccentricities."

This is the absurd nature of Camus' tragedy. Pestilence is the great equalizer, it chooses its victims irrespective of class or character. Tragedy is not as we see it in most stories, it acts with mechanical, non-reasoning randomness, affecting ordinary people who are unequipped to handle it.

Tarrou is tragically taken by the plague in its dying hours, a final victim and strike straight to the heart of Rieux, the man who put up the best fight of anyone. Even he is not spared from its wake. The following day, as the street fills with jubilant crowds for the subsiding of their oppressor, Rieux receives a telegram. His wife, absent from the story due to being stuck in hospice care outside the city, has passed away. Rieux later joins the celebrating crowds in the street, on the way to see another patient. He feels at one with the people, having intimately shared in their sorrow day in and day out.

The Plague at once acknowledges some of the deepest sorrows of the human spirit and yet comes out with a measured optimism for humanity, "to state quite simply what we learn in a time of pestilence: that there are more things to admire in man than to despise... on the whole men are more good than bad... But they are more or less ignorant; and it is this that we call virtue or vice." This is Camus' cure for the absurd. In the face of what can surely lead to despair and listlessness, one must live a humble life of duty, paying careful attention to defer the plague within one's heart, and indulge in love, hope, and friendship, lest they be taken away from us at a moment's notice.